Hacked Attention: A Father–Son Story of ADHD as a Cybersecurity Superpower

Abbas & Murtaza (Taz) Kudrati



CYBERCON 2026
AUSTRALIAN CYBER CONFERENCE

Presented by AISA

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Hacked Attention: A Father–Son Story of ADHD as a Cybersecurity Superpower

Exploring neurodivergent thinking across two generations of cyber careers

Two generations. The same wiring.

Abbas Kudrati
Field CISO, APCJ · F5

Field CISO APCJ at F5. 25+ years in cyber. Author, Professor of Practice, AISA Fellow.

Murtaza "Taz" Kudrati
L1 SOC Analyst · Ernst & Young

Early-career SOC analyst. Alert triage, detection and escalation.

40 Minutes | **2** Generations | **1** Industry | ∞ Possibilities

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This Might Be You

Relatable ADHD traits that might resonate with you or someone you know

56%
Diagnosed at 18+ · CDC 2024

1 in 20
Australians have ADHD

Struggle with routine tasks
Repetitive work feels draining; need variety to stay engaged

Thrive in crisis
Excel under pressure; perform best in high-stakes situations

Hyperfocus, then crash
Deep focus bursts followed by exhaustion

Jump between ideas quickly
Rapid context switching; easily bored by repetition

Spot patterns others miss
Unique perspective; see connections others don't

Creative problem-solving
Non-linear thinking; innovative solutions

Audience Check

Who here relates to even one of these traits?
Raise your hand if you see yourself in this.

Share Your Experience

Key Insight

These are traits, not verdicts. In most jobs they cost you. In a few cyber roles they pay. That difference is design, not luck.

Why This Matters in Cybersecurity

Understanding the industry context and the recognition problem

The Metric That Disappeared

Until 2024 every talk like this opened with a workforce gap number. ISC2 stopped publishing one in the 2025 study — participants ranked critical skills above headcount two years running.

The Recognition Problem

"What if we're overlooking the very minds we need?"
The people doing the work and the people doing the hiring see two different professions.

The Talent Is Already Here

Hyperfocus, pattern recognition and non-linear thinking map onto map onto incident response and threat hunting. 12% of the ISC2 ISC2 2025 base is already neurodivergent.

33%

Lack budget to staff teams

ISC2

29%

Can't afford the skills needed

ISC2

73%

Of ND pros say cyber suits them

ISC2

45%

Of their colleagues agree

ISC2

Prevalence
6.0% of US adults (one in 16) have a current ADHD diagnosis.

CDC 2024

SOURCES: ISC2 2025 Cybersecurity Workforce Study (n=16,029) • ISC2 Neurodivergence in Cybersecurity (n=15,852) • Staley et al., CDC MMWR 2024



PART 2 · OUR STORIES

Our Stories

Two generations. One brain. The same wiring.

02

I knew at five. The job didn’t exist exist yet.

> *Where is your documentation?*

> *Stop jumping between things.*

> *Just follow the change process.*

1997. Sysadmin, then network engineering, then IT audit. Change control, patch schedules, audit evidence — the most routine work in technology.

But every outage? Every crisis? Every ambiguous problem nobody else wanted? I came alive.

I had the diagnosis at five. What I didn’t have was a job description.

THE REFRAME

What the work didn’t want yet

Hyperfocus	→	Deep analysis
Pattern spotting	→	Anomaly detection
Context switching	→	Incident response
Curiosity	→	Threat hunting

The 'problems' were capabilities. The industry hadn't built a role for them yet.

I didn’t change. The work did.

THE TIMELINE

1997
Sysadmin, network engineering, IT audit.

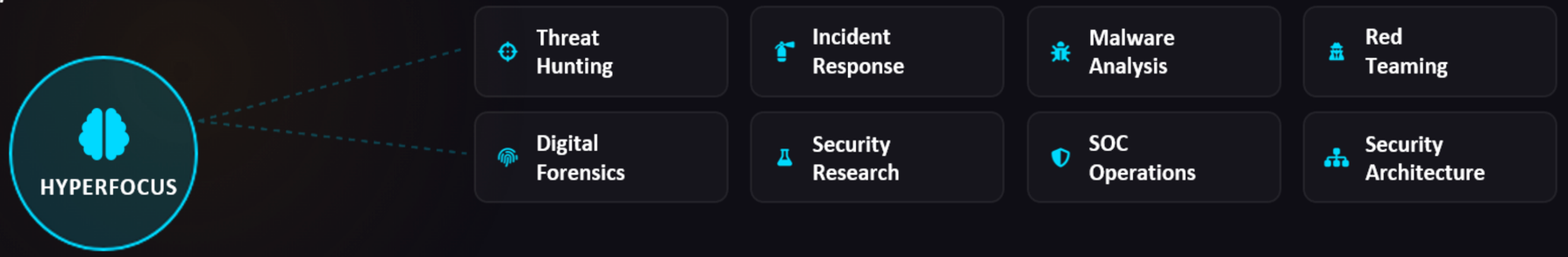
2003
Moved into security. First time the work fit.

SINCE
The roles that reward this arrived after I did.

THE REVEAL

Where hyperfocus goes to work

The same wiring that made school hard makes these roles feel like home.
like home.



- *Hyperfocus doesn't need to be fixed. It needs a worthy problem.*

Taz's Journey - From LEGO to Cyber

Childhood hyperfocus to SOC analyst: connecting systems thinking to security operations

Early Career

Taz Kudrati

SOC Analyst

- Early career · 2024–present

L1
SOC Analyst, EY

Daily
Alert triage

First SOC Experience

Everyone warned me about alert fatigue before I started.

Expected:	Alert noise would grind grind me down
Actual:	It was the part that kept kept me engaged

LEGO Builder
Systems thinking, complex structures

→

Network Explorer
Curiosity about connections

→

SOC Analyst
Pattern recognition, threat detection

Where ADHD Helped

Alert Triage
Rapid categorization of security alerts

Pattern Spotting
Identifying anomalies in data

Staying Engaged
Maintaining focus during analysis

Taz's Journey: From childhood curiosity to cybersecurity

SOC Alert Example - Pattern Detection

How Taz worked a low-priority DNS alert into a confirmed C2 escalation

SOC Alert: Suspicious DNS DNS Activity

14:32:15 UTC

Critical

Source IP:	192.168.1.***
Destination:	suspicious-domain.com
Pattern:	DNS queries every 30s
Duration:	2 hours 15 minutes

30s
Query interval

2h15
Beacon duration

Detection Timeline

Escalated

1	2	3	4
Alert 14:32:15	Analysis 14:35:22	Pattern ID 14:38:45	Escalation 14:42:10

Outcome: Threat Confirmed

The DNS pattern was identified as a C2 communication attempt. The threat was escalated to the incident response team for containment.

10
Minutes to escalation

C2
Beaconing confirmed

ADHD Strengths Used

Hyperfocus on pattern recognition, rapid context switching switching between alerts, and ability to spot anomalies in anomalies in large datasets.

Hyperfocus	Pattern Rec.	Rapid Switch
Deep concentration	Anomaly detection	Context agility

Illustrative — not a client detection



PART 3 · THE ADHD ADVANTAGE

The Advantage

Where the traits pay, and where they cost.



PART 3 · THE REFRAME

ADHD Traits as Cyber Advantages

TRAIT	TRADITIONAL VIEW		CYBER ADVANTAGE
Hyperfocus	Obsession	→	Deep analysis under pressure
Distractibility	Lack of focus	→	Rapid context switching
Curiosity	Easily bored	→	Threat exploration & hypothesis
Non-linear thinking	Scattered	→	Adversarial, creative thinking

The same wiring — reframed for a field built on chaos.

Where ADHD Excels in Cyber Roles

Mapping neurodivergent traits to cybersecurity functions

ADHD Strengths

ISC2 found neurodivergent professionals cluster above average in threat intelligence, data protection and cryptography roles.

5% Threat intel

6% Data protection

Key Insight

"Different minds don't weaken cyber defence — they strengthen it."

SOC / Incident Response

Fast triage & analysis

- Rapid alert triage
- Anomaly detection
- Calm in chaos

Threat Hunting

Pattern recognition

- Curiosity-driven
- Pattern spotting
- Pivoting skills

Red Teaming

Adversarial thinking

- Creative paths
- Misdirection
- Out-of-box thinking

Strategy & Architecture

Systems thinking

- Connecting dots
- Scenario design
- Big picture view

Role mapping: ADHD strengths in cybersecurity

Let's Be Honest - Challenges & Realities

Acknowledging the real struggles of ADHD in cybersecurity

Documentation Fatigue

Struggle with maintaining detailed logs, reports, and documentation. Long-term tasks feel overwhelming and draining.

Cognitive Overload

Managing multiple alerts, systems, and tasks simultaneously leads to mental exhaustion and decision fatigue.

44%
Authentic at work

60%
Job satisfaction

The Cost of Masking

Lower job satisfaction and fewer manager-level roles (45% vs 51%). Masking compounds the cost.

Masking & Stigma

Constantly hiding neurodivergent traits to fit workplace expectations, leading to increased stress and anxiety.

Priority Management

Difficulty prioritizing tasks, often getting lost in details without clear direction or structure.

What Helps

Breaking tasks into smaller chunks, using automation tools, and setting clear boundaries between work and rest periods.

Honest discussion of ADHD challenges in cybersecurity

What Managers Get Wrong About ADHD

Common misconceptions vs. reality in the workplace

"They just need to focus harder"
Managers believe ADHD is a willpower issue and employees should simply "try harder" to concentrate.

"Can't handle responsibility"
Assumption that ADHD means inability to manage tasks or lead projects effectively.

"Distracted means unproductive"
Equating distractibility with lack of productivity or poor work ethic.

"Need constant supervision"
Belief that ADHD employees require micromanagement and constant oversight.

Different cognitive processing
ADHD brains process information **differently**, not worse. They excel at pattern recognition and creative problem-solving.

Thrive under pressure
Many ADHD professionals **excel in crisis situations** and high-stakes environments where others struggle.

Hyperfocus on engaging tasks
When interested, they can achieve **deep focus** for extended periods, often exceeding neurotypical performance.

Autonomy with structure
Need **clear frameworks** and autonomy, not micromanagement. Success comes from understanding how they work best.

Common misconceptions about ADHD in cybersecurity teams

PART 4 · STRATEGIES

What Helped Us — Practical Strategies

Real-world approaches that worked for both Abbas and Taz

Abbas Kudrati
Senior Cybersecurity Leader

Structure the Chaos
Working agreements, cadences, and clear frameworks

Partner & Delegate
Play to strengths and delegate delegate effectively

Energy Management
Protected focus blocks and strategic breaks

Cognitive Load
Managing mental energy and avoiding burnout

Taz Kudrati
Early Career SOC Analyst

Tools & Routines
Dashboards and automated workflows

Break Tasks Down
Defining "done" upfront and breaking work

Environment Setup
Headphones, lighting optimized for focus

Team Support
Finding mentors and sharing how you work

Directional Outcomes

Personal experience — Abbas & Taz Kudrati. Individual outcomes vary.

Sustained Energy
Fewer late-week crashes; protected focus windows kept output steady.

Sharper Signal
Pattern recognition surfaced earlier when cognitive overload was managed.

Lower Burnout
Recovery cadence prevented the boom-bust cycle we knew too well.

Psychological Safety
Being able to name how we work unlocked how well we work.

Interactive Discussion Framework

Visual prompts and questions for audience engagement

Facilitation Notes

Goal: Encourage reflection on neurodiversity in your teams. Use these questions to spark meaningful dialogue about hiring, culture, and performance.

Hiring practices | Team dynamics | Productivity metrics | Accommodations

Tip: Start with the question that resonates most with your current team challenges.

How does your team identify talent?

Hiring

What signals do you look for that might indicate neurodivergent thinking?

What barriers prevent disclosure?

Change

Fear of stigma, lack of awareness, or other factors?

Have you seen ADHD strengths in action?

Performance

Examples of pattern recognition or creative problem-solving?

What accommodations exist in your org?

Culture

Are there flexible work arrangements or support systems?

How do you measure productivity?

Performance

Traditional metrics vs. output-based assessment?

What would you change tomorrow?

Change

One practical change to support neurodiversity?



PART 4 · TAKING ACTION

Taking Action

You are either being managed, or doing the managing.

Playbook for Individuals

Practical strategies to thrive with ADHD in cybersecurity

1. Lean into Strengths

Choose cybersecurity roles that match your natural cognitive patterns. Focus on areas where ADHD traits become advantages: threat hunting, incident response, or pattern recognition.

- ✓ Find roles that fit your brain

2. Build Systems, Not Willpower

Use automation and templates to reduce cognitive load. Create working agreements, checklists, and standardized processes instead of relying on discipline.

- ✓ Automate repetitive tasks

3. Externalize Memory

Offload information to tools: notes, kanban boards, reminders, and documentation systems. Don't rely on your brain to remember everything.

- ✓ Use tools to free up mental space

4. Time-Box Your Work

Break tasks into sprints with clear definition of done. Use timers, Pomodoro technique, and set hard stops to prevent burnout.

- ✓ Set clear boundaries and breaks

5. Find Mentors & Share

Connect with mentors who understand neurodiversity. Share how you work best with your team and advocate for your needs.

- ✓ Build your support network

Quick Tips

- Use noise-canceling headphones
- Set calendar reminders
- Take regular breaks
- Create visual workflows

Start small: Implement one strategy at a time. time. Don't try to change everything at once. once.

Track progress: Monitor what works and adjust your approach based on results.

Be kind to yourself: Progress, not perfection. ADHD is a different way of thinking, not a flaw.

Guide for Leaders & Organizations

Rethinking hiring, support, and career development for neurodiverse talent

Rethink Interviews

Replace traditional Q&A with practical exercises, paired problem-solving, and real-world scenarios

Practical exercises | Pair programming | Scenario-based

Hire for Capability

Focus on outcomes and problem-solving skills, not just conformity to traditional expectations

Skills assessment | Portfolio review

Flexible Environments

Design workspaces that accommodate sensory needs and different working styles

Remote work | Flexible hours | Quiet spaces

Clear Priorities & Structure

Provide clear priorities, small batches, written context, and well-defined expectations

Kanban boards | Sprint planning | Documentation

Normalize Accommodations

Make accommodations standard practice, not special treatment

Assistive tech | Modified schedules | Support tools

Specialist Career Paths

Create non-linear career paths that value deep expertise and different working styles

Technical tracks | Mentorship | Skill development

THE BIG IDEA

The cyber skills shortage is not just a pipeline pipeline problem — it's a recognition problem. problem.

— Abbas & Taz Kudrati

Spot strengths sooner

Identify neurodivergent talent early through through practical assessments

Design for different minds

Create flexible environments that maximize cognitive strengths

Measure what matters

Focus on capability and outcomes, not conformity

73%
Of ND pros say cyber suits them
ISC2 Neurodivergence Study (n=15,852)

45%
Of their colleagues agree
Source: ISC2

12%
Of the workforce is neurodivergent
ISC2 2025 Workforce Study (n=16,029)


"Different minds don't weaken cyber defence, they strengthen it."
~ Abbas & Taz Kudrati
Try one change with your team this month.
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Q & A

Let's continue the conversation.

Abbas's LinkedIn Code



Taz's LinkedIn Code

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Resources - Australia

Verified Australian organisations and primary sources · links checked September 2026

ADHD Australia

National charity. Runs a dedicated Employment team supporting employers and employees on workplace ADHD.

www.adhdaustralia.org.au

AADPA

Australasian ADHD Professionals Association. Publishes the Australian Evidence-Based Clinical Practice Guideline for ADHD.

www.aadpa.org.au

Black Dog Institute

Australian research institute for mental health, including ADHD research and workplace mental health programs.

www.blackdoginstitute.org.au

Neurodiversity in Workplace

Australian-founded. Partners include La Trobe, Curtin, AustCyber, DXC and Splunk. Carries cybersecurity-specific resources.

www.neurodiversity.org.au

Untapped · Genius Armoury

Australian social enterprise building cybersecurity talent pathways for neurodivergent candidates.

www.untapped-group.com

Beyond Blue

National mental health support, including ADHD resources and a 24/7 support line.

www.beyondblue.org.au

Peer-Reviewed & Primary Sources

Social & Economic Costs of ADHD
Sciberras et al. · J Atten Disord 26(1)
2022

ADHD Diagnosis & Treatment in Adults
Staley et al. · CDC MMWR 73(40)
2024

Moving Beyond Disclosure
Kalmanovich-Cohen & Stanton · Front Psychol
2025